Office of Research Assurance

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP - 410: NASA IRB Initial Full Board Review

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Versions
410	8/27/2025	v.1.1	v.1

Purpose

SOP-410 defines the processes and procedures for initial review by the convened NASA Institutional Review Board (IRB).

Policy

1. The NASA IRB conducts an initial review of research that does not meet the criteria for expedited or exempt review at convened meetings regardless of funding source.
2. The NASA IRB only approves research meeting the federal criteria for approval found in 14 CFR 1230.111 and/or 21 CFR 56.111.
3. The NASA IRB also reviews the informed consent, informed consent process, and all related study documentation per federal regulations and ethical standards.

Procedures

1. Principal Investigators (PI) request prospective IRB review and approval from the NASA IRB for all new human subjects research (HSR) and any modifications/changes to approved research through the eIRB.
2. NASA IRB Office responsibilities
    a. **Screening/pre-review.** Upon receipt of the submission in the eIRB, the NASA IRB office staff conducts a pre-review and makes an initial determination. If the project is deemed human subjects research and does not qualify for expedited or exempt review, the submission is assigned to the convened board once pre-review is complete.
        i. During pre-review, the submission may be returned to the PI for questions, clarifications, or updates. The NASA IRB office will consult with IRB Chairs and members as needed, particularly with respect to assessments of risks and benefits.
        ii. The NASA IRB staff ensures that all listed researchers have completed the required training. If any researcher has not completed the required training within the last three years or their training has expired, the IRB staff will notify the PI in writing.

iii. When pre-review is complete, IRB office staff documents the following within the eIRB:
    1. Regulatory oversight (NASA indicated as “Other federal agency,” FDA, etc.)
    2. Need for any additional determinations
    3. Type of research (e.g., biomedical, SBER)
    4. Additional study features, such as
        a. Clinical Trial – meets either the Revised Common Rule and/or FDAAA clinical trial definition(s)
        b. Inclusion of a Certificate of Confidentiality (CoC)
        c. Collaborative – researchers from outside of NASA are engaged in HSR for the study
        d. Multi-site – involves the same research protocol completed at more than one location (site) (note: rare for NASA studies)

iv. If the researcher indicates that the project involves an investigational new drug (IND) or investigational device exemption (IDE), the NASA IRB staff confirms the validity of the IND or IDE number by ensuring that the researcher has included a copy of the detailed protocol from the sponsor (containing the IND or IDE number) and/or verification statement from the sponsor or the Food and Drug Administration (FDA). In situations where a device does not have an IDE, the IRB staff informs the reviewers that a nonsignificant risk (NSR) determination is needed.

b. **Ancillary Review.** The IRB staff determines whether additional expertise is necessary to conduct the review and may ask a consultant to review the protocol. Some submissions require additional reviews to ensure the §_.111 approval criteria can be assessed during the convened meeting. Examples include, but are not limited to:
    i. **Crew Office Review:** Submissions that include prospective in-flight and/or pre- and post-flight data collection from astronauts receive an ancillary review by the NASA IRB Crew (CB) Representative.
    ii. **Safety Office Review:** Submissions that include equipment or devices not previously reviewed by the NASA Safety Office receive an ancillary review by the NASA IRB Safety Representative.
c. **Convened Board Review:** Following the initial pre-review and completion of any necessary ancillary reviews, the NASA IRB Office assigns the submission to a **Convened Board**.
    i. **Assignment**
        1. The IRB staff schedules protocols for review in the order they are received. Submission deadlines are posted on the IRB website. Protocols must be ready for assignment to the board agenda by the published due date to be reviewed at the scheduled meeting.
        2. Approximately two weeks prior to each convened meeting, the IRB staff will provide the meeting agenda and all review

materials to IRB members in the eIRB. The documentation provided to IRB members includes all applicable sections of the application.

3. IRB members review all information in advance of the meeting in enough depth to be familiar with the protocol, to be prepared to discuss the protocol at the meeting, and to determine whether the research meets the regulatory criteria for approval. The reviewers also ensure that the research meets ethical principles and standards for protecting research participants.
4. Consultants may provide comments or recommendations in writing to the IRB prior to the meeting or may be asked to attend the convened meeting to participate in the review. The IRB staff maintains documentation of written comments and reports. In cases when the consultant participates in the meeting, the minutes of the meeting will document the information provided by the consultant.

ii. IRB Member Review

1. Reviewers who have a conflict of interest related to a submission must inform the NASA IRB and staff of the conflict. Conflicted members are recused from the deliberation and vote.
2. Reviewers have access to the above-referenced materials submitted in the eIRB system.
3. Reviewers may provide comments within the in eIRB.
4. Reviewers may contact the PI for any clarification needed via “Request for Clarification” within the eIRB.

iii. Convened Meeting

1. The NASA IRB:
    a. Confirms that the research meets ethical principles and standards for protecting research subjects 14 CFR 1230.111/21 CFR 56.111.
    b. Confirms the requirements for informed consent (§_.116, §_.117) are met.
    c. Determines the approval period, as appropriate to the degree of risk but not less frequently than once per year (unless the IRB determines that the research is minimal risk and meets exempt or expedited review criteria).
    d. For research involving a device where the PI or the sponsor has not obtained an IDE, the IRB determines what action(s) is needed (whether the PI needs to obtain an IDE or whether the device meets criteria for abbreviated requirements at 21 CFR 812.2(b)). The IRB reviews relevant information including, but not

limited to, a description of the device, the proposed investigational plan and participant selection criteria.

e. For research involving an investigational drug, biologic, therapeutic dietary supplement, substance affecting structure or function of the body, or product intended to diagnose, cure, mitigate, treat, or prevent disease, the IRB confirms that an IND has been secured and investigational drugs are used in approved research protocols and under the direction of approved researchers.

2. NASA IRB Determinations include:
    a. **Approved**. Accepted as is, no changes are required. Criteria for approval are met.
    b. **Contingent Approval** (**Modifications Required to Secure "Approved")** Minor specific changes are required and are not necessary to confirm approval criteria are met. The NASA IRB Staff notes the stipulated changes required for approval in eIRB.
        1. Stipulated changes are directives for which completion may be verified by IRB Office staff.
        2. "Approval date" represents the date that the IRB made the decision to contingently approve the study, not the day the decision is recorded.
        3. "Effective date" is set to the day the modifications are reviewed and accepted by IRB staff.
    c. **Tabled (Modifications Required to Secure "Approved"**) Major revisions are required in order to assess the approval criteria. The NASA IRB Staff notes the stipulated changes required in eIRB. These changes are reviewed by the convened NASA IRB.
    d. **Disapproved** Researchers are provided with suggested revisions and encouraged to resubmit for convened IRB review.
3. If the PI has concerns regarding the IRB decision/recommendations for changes in the project, he/she/they must submit them to the IRB for consideration including a written justification for changing the IRB decision.
4. **Documentation of convened board review** is recorded in the eIRB system.
    a. NASA IRB staff record (within the eIRB) must include:
        1. Documentation of the risk determination
        2. Period of approval and justification for approval period less than 1 year

3. Additional documentation related to study-specific findings including, as applicable but not limited to:
    a. Waiver or alteration of the informed consent process [§ _.116(f)]
    b. Waiver of the requirement for documentation of consent [§_.117(c)]
    c. Research for which NASA determines that use of single IRB is not appropriate [§_.114(b)(ii)]

5. **Post Review**:
    a. Following the convened meeting and documentation within the eIRB, IRB staff:
        1. finalizes study materials within the eIRB,
        2. prepares the appropriate determination letter, and
        3. distributes to PI/PI proxy through the eIRB system.

References

14 CFR 1230
21 CFR 50, 56, 312, 812

Version #	Version Notes:	Originated By:	Approved By:	Date Approved:
v.1.1	Minor updates to text, grammatical corrections	K. Ntow	M. Covington	27Aug2025
v.1	original	J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	7Aug2024